



ISSUE #1

BACKYARD ROCKETS



THE OXIDIZER GAP

BUILD ANOTHER WAY.

In the near-future Mojave, water does not flow unless the network allows it.

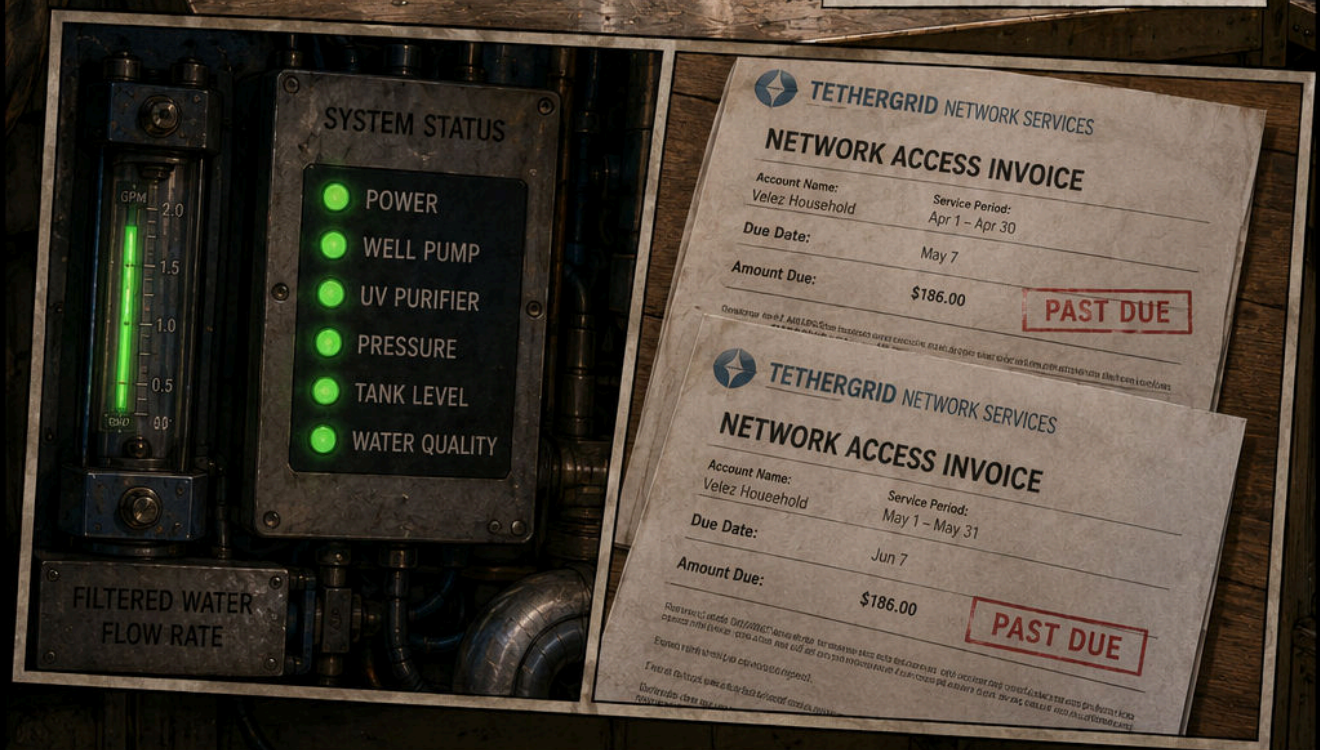
Arvin, Lucia and Milo turn salvaged machinery into homemade rockets and an independent network that desert communities can control for themselves. Every launch pushes that alternative closer to reality - and makes Launch-Shop easier to find.

This combined production edition presents The Oxidizer Gap and The Copper Lattice in the rebuilt RexPrompt sequence: one clean launch in each issue, a visible consequence on the ground, and a network whose hardest problem is not propulsion but shared control.

THE DRYLINE REPORT



THE PURIFIER WORKS. THE WELL HAS WATER. TETHERGRID DISABLED BOTH AFTER THE VELEZ FAMILY MISSED TWO NETWORK PAYMENTS.





THE WELD
LOOKS CONFIDENT.
THE FRACTURE
DISAGREES.

WHAT WOULD
MAKE YOU TRUST THE
WHOLE ASSEMBLY,
NOT JUST THE WELD?



A FAILURE WE
CAN PREDICT, CONTAIN,
AND WALK AWAY
FROM.



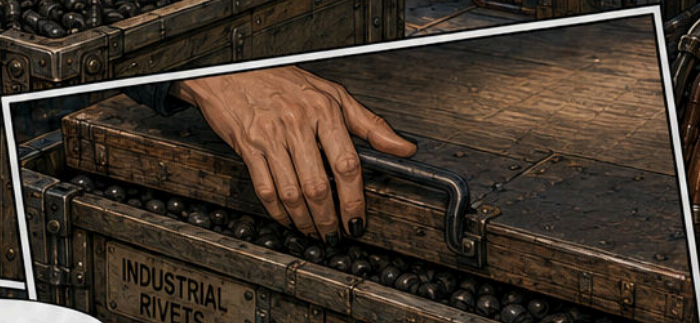
SO TRUST MEANS
KNOWING HOW IT
BREAKS?



TRUST MEANS IT
DOES NOT GET TO
SURPRISE MY CREW.



I AM
SORTING WHAT KEEPS
THE NEXT LAUNCH ALIVE
FROM WHAT ONLY
SLOWS US DOWN.



DO YOU EVER LOOK
AT A PART AND SEE WHAT
IT USED TO BE?



I SEE WHAT IT
SURVIVED, THEN I ASK
WHAT IT CAN BECOME.

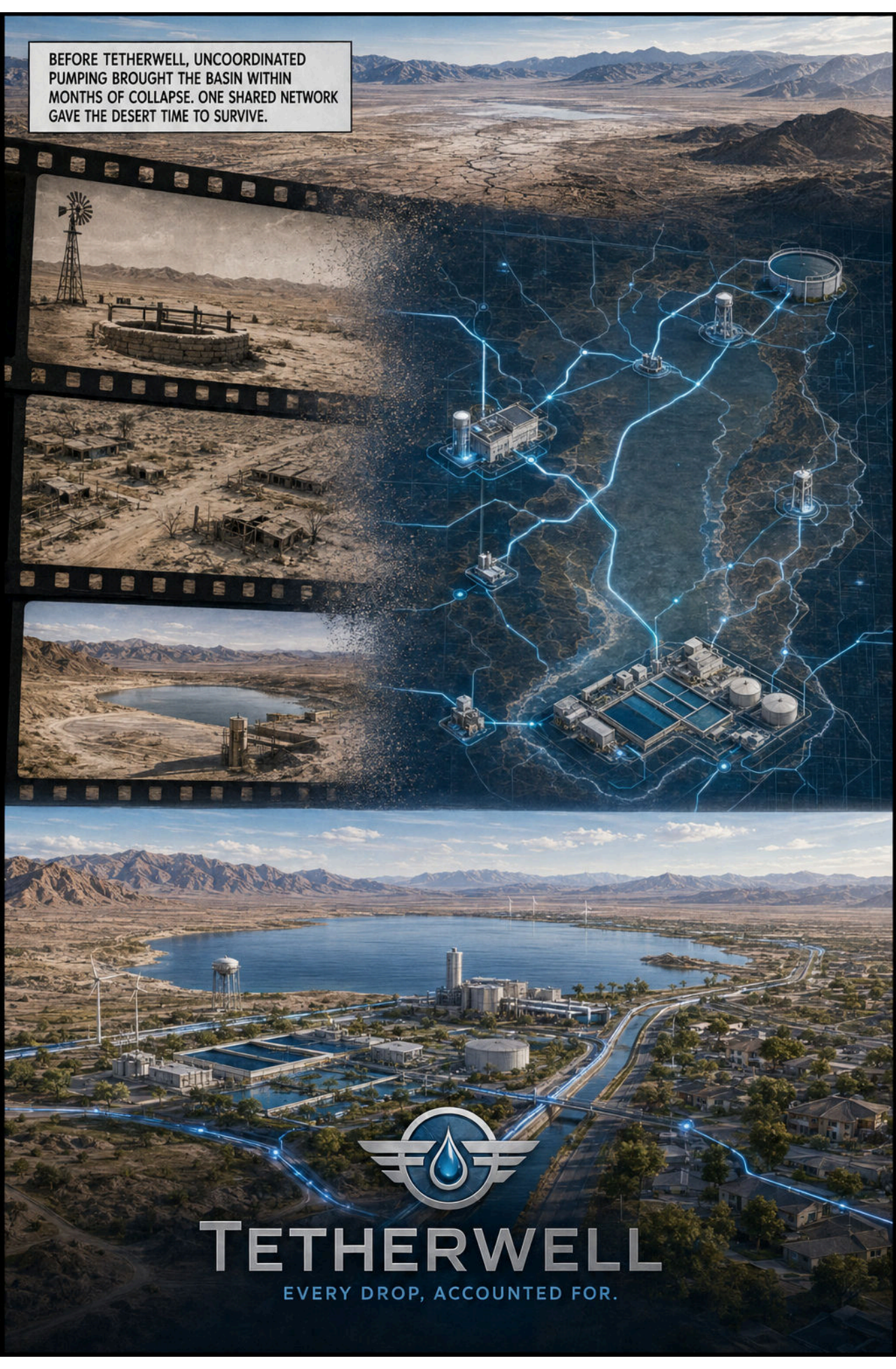


I LIKE
KNOWING WHERE
THINGS CAME
FROM.

YOU KEEP THE
BIOGRAPHY. I WILL
MAKE SURE IT GETS
ANOTHER CHAPTER.

SAME HOBBY.
DIFFERENT
ENDING.

BEFORE TETHERWELL, UNCOORDINATED
PUMPING BROUGHT THE BASIN WITHIN
MONTHS OF COLLAPSE. ONE SHARED NETWORK
GAVE THE DESERT TIME TO SURVIVE.



TETHERWELL

EVERY DROP, ACCOUNTED FOR.

THAT BEACON IS
HOW A VILLAGE CALLS
FOR HELP. WE DO NOT
TURN THEIR LIFELINE
INTO OUR WEAPON.



WHAT WOULD
YOU DO IF NOBODY
WERE CHASING US?



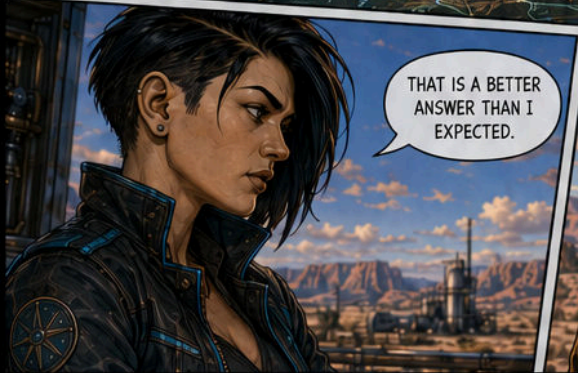
BUILD
SLOWER.



BUILD OPENLY. TEACH
EVERY SETTLEMENT TO
LAUNCH WITHOUT US.



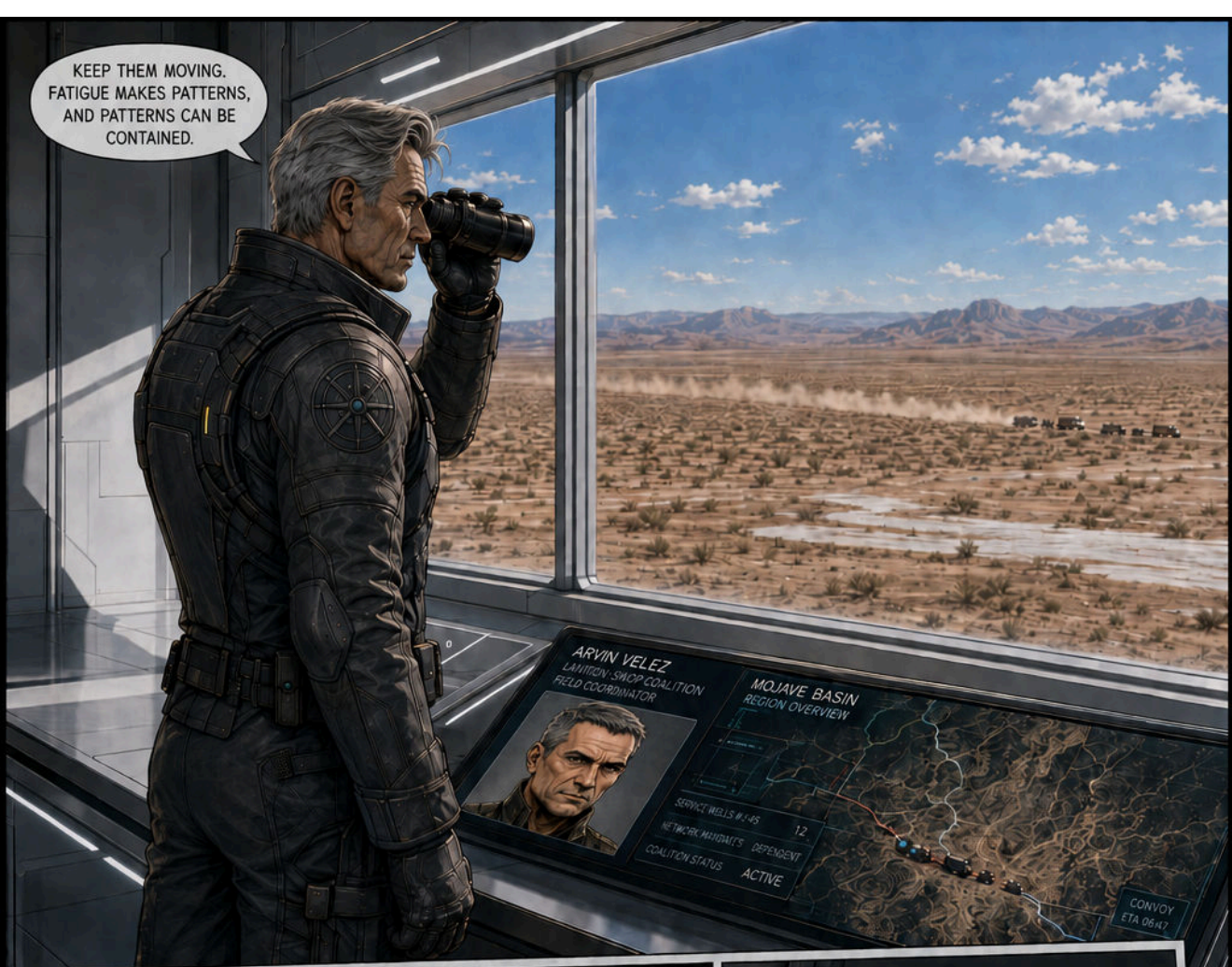
THAT IS A BETTER
ANSWER THAN I
EXPECTED.



YOU DID ASK AN
OPEN-ENDED
QUESTION.



KEEP THEM MOVING.
FATIGUE MAKES PATTERNS,
AND PATTERNS CAN BE
CONTAINED.



ARVIN VELEZ
LAWTON SWOP COALITION
FIELD COORDINATOR



MOJAVE BASIN
REGION OVERVIEW

SERVICE WELLS #1-45 12
NETWORK MAINTENANCE DEPENDENT
COALITION STATUS ACTIVE



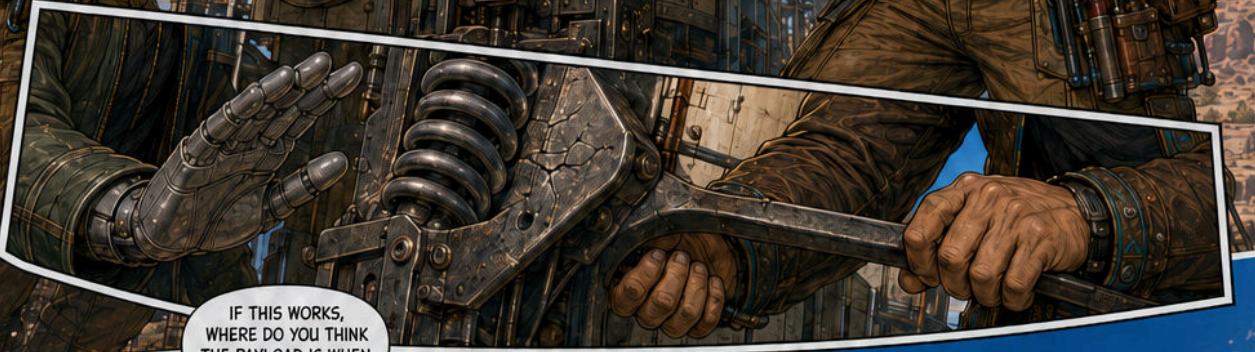
WHAT DO YOU
THINK THEY BELIEVE
THEY ARE
PROTECTING?

NOT THE HARDWARE.
PEOPLE RARELY RISK
THIS MUCH FOR
HARDWARE.





EASY, MILO.
ONE MORE TURN AND
THE BRACKET BECOMES
THE FAILURE.



IF THIS WORKS,
WHERE DO YOU THINK
THE PAYLOAD IS WHEN
WE GO TO SLEEP?



CROSSING THE DARK
WHILE WE SLEEP, GIVING
ANOTHER SETTLEMENT A
TETHERWELL SIGNAL THEY
CONTROL.



THAT WAS
ALMOST
POETIC.



ORBITAL MECHANICS
CAN BE POETIC.
DO NOT TELL ANYONE
I SAID THAT.



WHEN DID YOU FIRST
DECIDE A LAUNCH WAS
WORTH GETTING CAUGHT
FOR?

IF THAT SPRING GOES,
THE VALVE STAYS OPEN. SHOW
ME THE BACKUP BEFORE EITHER
OF US TOUCHES IT.



I NEVER DECIDED
GETTING CAUGHT WAS
WORTHWHILE.

THAT SOUNDS
REASSURING.

I DECIDED THE PEOPLE
WAITING FOR THAT SIGNAL
WERE WORTH THE RISK. THEN
I ASKED ALL OF YOU TO DECIDE
FOR YOURSELVES.



THE FORBIDDEN FREQUENCY
REACHES THE BLACKOUT ZONE. I WILL
TELL ARVIN BEFORE WE INSTALL IT, BUT
I NEED TO KNOW IT WORKS FIRST.



YOU KNOW
WHAT BAD PLANS
ARE GOOD FOR?



THEY
INCLUDE
US?



THEY EXPOSE
WHAT WE ARE
ACTUALLY PROTECTING.
THEN WE BUILD A
BETTER PLAN AROUND
THAT.







WE IGNITE NOW OR
THE WINDOW CLOSES.
MILO, STAY WITH ME
ON THE FEED
PRESSURE.



WHAT DID YOU
THINK YOU WERE GOING
TO BE DOING AT
MY AGE?

DESIGNING
SOMETHING SAFER,
WITH A BUDGET LARGE
ENOUGH TO HIDE THE
COMPROMISES.

BETTER?

CLEANER, YES.
BETTER? NOT UNTIL
I FOUND THIS CREW.





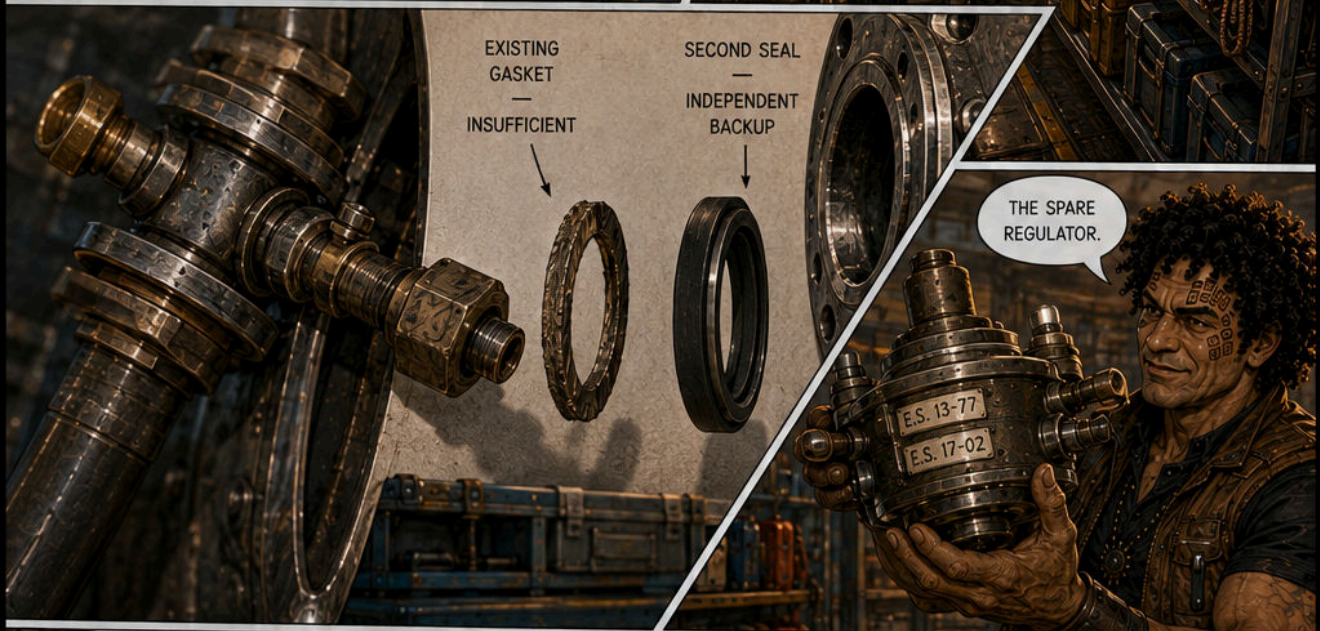
SLOW POUR. IF THE
SEAL STARTS SINGING,
WE STOP BEFORE ANYBODY
LOSES A HAND.





THIS GASKET FAILS, THE
PRESSURE RUNS AWAY. NOBODY
MOVES UNTIL WE GIVE IT A
SECOND SEAL.

IF WE HAVE TO
LEAVE ONE THING BEHIND,
WHAT IS IT?



EXISTING
GASKET
—
INSUFFICIENT

SECOND SEAL
—
INDEPENDENT
BACKUP

THE SPARE
REGULATOR.



NOT THE REGULATOR.
IT IS HEAVY BECAUSE IT
HAS SAVED US TWICE.

YOU ANSWERED
BEFORE I
FINISHED.

I KNOW, THAT IS
WHY I ANSWERED
BEFORE YOU
FINISHED.



WE GET THREE SECONDS
OF CLEAN BURN. THAT IS
ENOUGH IF WE ALL HIT
OUR MARKS.

WHAT PART
OF LAUNCH DO YOU
ACTUALLY LIKE?



THE BREATH
AFTER COMMITMENT.

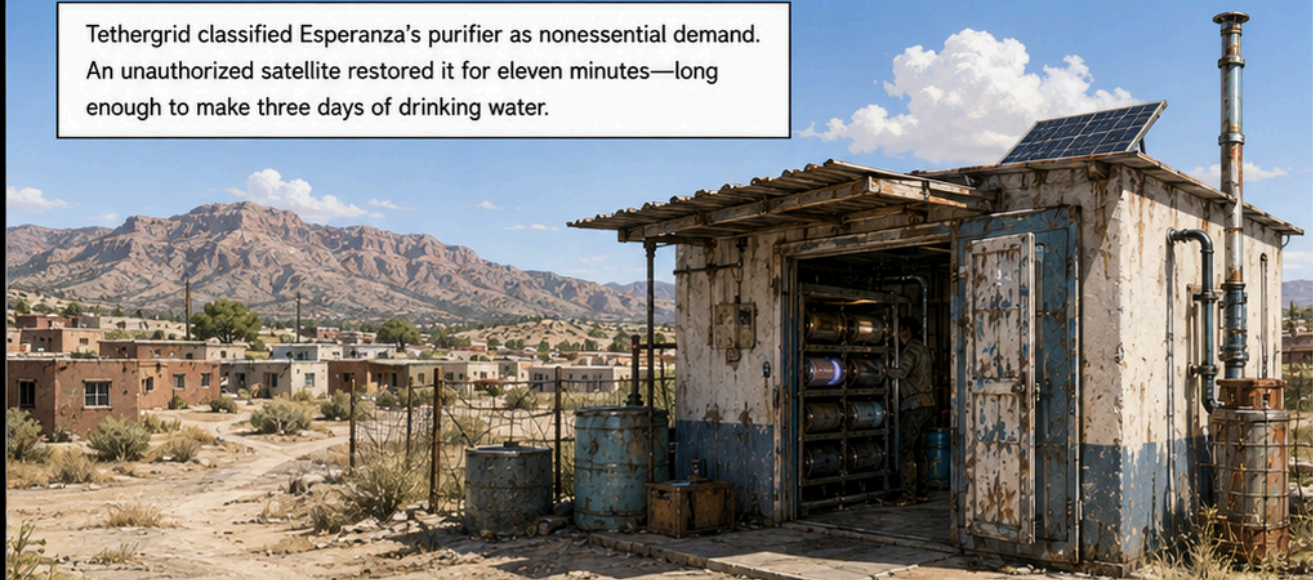
WHY?

BECAUSE THE WORK IS
FINALLY OURS TO WITNESS,
NOT IMPROVE. FOR ONE
SECOND, WE SIMPLY MEET
WHAT WE BUILT.





Tethergrid classified Esperanza's purifier as nonessential demand. An unauthorized satellite restored it for eleven minutes—long enough to make three days of drinking water.





WILL THAT UNEVEN
BEAD OPEN UP WHEN THE AIR
THINS, OR AM I WORRYING AT
THE WRONG PART?



WHAT DO YOU
MISS WHEN WE STAY
PUT TOO LONG?



THE HORIZON
CHANGING. AND ALL OF
YOU COMPLAINING IN A
NEW LOCATION.



NOT
PEOPLE?



PEOPLE ARE WHY
MOVING MATTERS. THE
HORIZON JUST GIVES US
ROOM TO NOTICE.